Our men who were in Chinese hands had been kept out in the open and they had seen several bodies being fished out of the river. Whenever that happened, they were subjected to a fresh round of beatings. The sheer savagery of their response was in itself indicative of the losses they had suffered. Initially, they did not admit to any casualties at all; then many months later, admitted to four or five killed, including the CO on their side. An independent report by a group of Australian researchers put the figure to at least thirty-eight killed.[21] A separate Russian (TASS) report put the figure closer to forty-five killed, which was consistent with other intelligence reports, including those from the US.[22]

The PM, Shri Narendra Modi, visited Leh in July, accompanied by the CDS and myself. Interacting with the troops at Nimu, he lauded the bravery of our troops as also the 'bravery of all the proud sons of Mother India who made the supreme sacrifice at the Galwan Valley'.[23] The PM emphasized that the era of expansionism was over and that India's commitment to peace should not be seen as a sign of weakness. He also visited the Military Hospital at Leh to meet the injured personnel. This visit did much to raise our morale and only further strengthened our resolve.

16 June is Xi Jinping's birthday. This is not a day he will forget any time soon. For the first time in over two decades, the Chinese and the PLA had suffered fatal casualties. They had been following wolf-warrior diplomacy[24] and salami-slicing[25] tactics everywhere with impunity, browbeating smaller neighbours like Nepal and Bhutan, while staking their ever-increasing claims in the South China Sea, without having to pay any costs, especially in terms of human lives. It took India and the Indian Army to show to the world that enough is enough and to challenge the neighbourhood bully.

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